was dead. The boy had fever and, before the doctors could diagnose, he died. Do we tell Balakrishnan? By the time he reaches home, the funeral would be over. And he would not be allowed to come back to Vernon. Subbaiah was sobbing uncontrollably over the phone.

I told him to just listen as I talked. At the end of it, he should take a decision. I presented the pros and cons of Balakrishnan returning to India, mostly cons. I felt his return would deny him a good exposure that would help the young scientist a great deal. Back in India, he would join the rest of the family in mourning, and can do little else. I told Subbaiah that I may sound even heartless, but I am just being clinical, dispassionate, though the news was extremely saddening to me. Having said this, I wouldn't insist on Balakrishnan staying back. His short stay at SEP was not crucial for the project, I could spare him, but he had much to gain.

I told Subbaiah, 'My advice would be to not break the news to him till he completes the assignment. At the end of it, we will tell him. He would be extremely shocked, even furious at me, but I can handle that. Now, it's your decision.'

Subbaiah agreed. 'You are the best judge of my son,' he said. I hung up.

I didn't speak about it even to my wife. It was tough keeping such a sad secret. Balakrishnan would accompany me sometimes for shopping in Paris, and pick up toys for his son. I would discourage him from buying them, saying you get better things in India. I lied through my teeth. I sobbed within.

Balakrishnan did very well at SEP and it was time for his return. I helped him deposit his bags in the car. M Parasu Pillai, another scientist was travelling with Balakrishnan back to India. Once Balakrishnan had got into the car, I took Pillai aside. A Sampath, who was heading the programme coordination group, was with me.

'Pillai, I am giving you the toughest assignment ever.'

Pillai and Sampath looked curious with this introduction.

I said, 'Minutes before the aircraft touches down in Trivandrum, you have to tell Balakrishnan that his only son is no more. That the boy died a few days after Balakrishnan reached here. That his father spoke to me and I